

# Chicken Curry

Yogurt-based · garlic-forward · no tomato · stovetop

|       |          |                |                |
|-------|----------|----------------|----------------|
| YIELD | ACTIVE   | ONION RATIO    | FAT RATIO      |
| 6–8   | ~1.25 hr | 1:1 to protein | 10% of protein |

## KEY TARGETS

visual states — the bhuna is judged by eye, not clock

|                |                                                                                            |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Onion paste    | Deep brown, jammy — ~75% volume loss, smell sweet not sharp.                               |
| Bhuna (masala) | Oil separates — paste goes curdled & matte, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges. |
| Yogurt         | Oil separates again <b>after each addition</b> before the next.                            |
| Sauce          | Clings to the meat, coats a spoon.                                                         |
| Garlic finish  | Hits the nose immediately on serving.                                                      |
| Final          | Thick, glossy, not watery.                                                                 |

## INGREDIENTS

1.5 kg chicken batch

|                                 |        |                                  |       |
|---------------------------------|--------|----------------------------------|-------|
| Chicken boneless thigh, chunked | 1.5 kg | Garlic minced, for finish        | 30 g  |
| Onion sliced thin               | 1.5 kg | Salt ~12g at sear, rest to taste | 18 g  |
| Ghee (100 + 30 + 20)            | 150 g  | Lemon juice                      | 15 g  |
| Yogurt full-fat, room temp      | 225 g  | Kasuri methi crushed             | 2–3 g |
| Ginger-garlic paste DIY, below  | 60 g   | Green chilies slit               | 2–3   |

## SPICES

whole = bloom (step 4) · ground = fry in fat (step 5)

### WHOLE — BLOOM, STEP 4

|                |          |
|----------------|----------|
| Cumin seed     | 6 g      |
| Green cardamom | 4 pods   |
| Black cardamom | 2 pods   |
| Cinnamon       | 1 stick  |
| Bay            | 3 leaves |
| Cloves         | 4        |

### GROUND — FRY IN FAT, STEP 5

|                            |      |
|----------------------------|------|
| Kashmiri chili color, mild | 30 g |
| Hot chili                  | 7 g  |
| Turmeric                   | 4 g  |

### GARAM MASALA — USED IN TWO STAGES

|                                       |       |
|---------------------------------------|-------|
| Bloom half with ground spices, step 5 | 3.5 g |
| Finish half off heat, step 11         | 3.5 g |

**DIY ginger-garlic paste:** 60g garlic + 60g ginger (1:1), peeled. Blend with **15–30 ml water** — minimum to form a smooth paste. Yield **~120g**; use 60g here. Keeps **5–7 days** fridge, **3 months** frozen. Turns bitter after 24 hr at room temp — fresh is brighter.

# Build the Curry

## METHOD

stovetop — oil separation gates every stage

- 1 **Onions:** 100g ghee, add onions. **50–60 min medium**, stir every 5–7 min. Done: volume down ~75%, no steam releasing, smell sweet not sharp, color deep brown & jammy.
- 2 **Blend:** tilt the pot, immersion-blend the onions to a smooth paste in the residual fat — no water. (Traditional blender: remove center cap, cover with towel, vent steam.)
- 3 **Fry the paste (bhuna):** 30g ghee, return paste, **8–10 min medium**, stir constantly. Done: paste looks **curdled and matte**, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges. Non-negotiable — rushing = raw taste.
- 4 **Bloom:** push paste to the sides, add whole spices to the fat in the center, **30–45 sec** until fragrant and sizzling, stir in. Add 60g ginger-garlic paste, **2–3 min** until the raw smell is gone.
- 5 **Ground spices:** medium-low. Add the ground spices + the **first 3.5g garam masala (bloom half)**. Fry **45–60 sec** in the fat. Splash **50 ml water**, cook until oil separates.
- 6 **Yogurt:** low heat. Temper first — whisk **~5g hot paste** into the yogurt bowl (prevents curdling). Add **~30g at a time**, waiting for oil to separate before each. **10–12 min** total.
- 7 **Sear:** high heat. Add chicken, season with **~12g salt** (hold the rest). Sear **4–5 min** until opaque — building fond.
- 8 **Simmer:** add **~300 ml hot water**, scrape up the fond, cover and simmer until the chicken is cooked through — **~15–20 min** for thigh chunks. Stir once or twice.
- 9 **Reduce:** uncover, medium-high. Reduce until the sauce clings to the chicken, **8–12 min**. Now taste and bring to **final salt** (the held ~6g, to taste) — after reduction, not before.
- 10 **Garlic finish:** small pan, 20g ghee + 30g minced garlic + slit chilies. **60–90 sec** to just-golden edges (not brown). Pour into the curry.
- 11 **Finish:** off heat. Add the **second 3.5g garam masala (finish half)**, kasuri methi, 15g lemon. The garlic should hit your nose immediately.

## TROUBLESHOOTING

every fault traces to the bhuna or the reduction

| PROBLEM                    | CAUSE                              | FIX                                                         |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Watery / thin sauce</b> | Under-reduced onions; bhuna rushed | Reduce longer at step 9; oil must separate at steps 3, 5, 6 |
| <b>Tastes raw / flat</b>   | Bhuna rushed; bloom skipped        | No shortcuts on oil separation; bloom the spices in fat     |
| <b>No garlic punch</b>     | Finish garlic overcooked           | Golden edges only, not brown; add right before serving      |
| <b>Too hot / dry</b>       | Chili concentrated; not enough fat | Add 20–30g ghee — NOT water. Fat mellows heat.              |
| <b>Yogurt curdled</b>      | Cold yogurt; heat too high         | Room temp; temper first; keep heat low                      |